

Grading criteria for Theses

Preamble:

The following list of criteria is supposed to cover *all* different research fields and types of final student theses at the IMS.

The criteria have been selected to be general enough for this purpose, but at the same time to cover every aspect and to be specific and distinct, so that the evaluation is transparent.

Some aspects might be not applicable for a certain thesis; this is up to the supervisor.

The weighting of the grading categories for the final grade is up to the supervisor (and depends also on the thesis type). However, it has to be clear for the students which parts are weighted more or less!

The common recommendation is that the supervisor/examiner presents the criteria to the student at the beginning of the thesis and explains/justifies the given grade at the end based on this list.

A. ORGANISATION

SELF-ORGANISATION

- general time management
- meeting deadlines/milestones
- adequate independence/autonomy

COMMITMENT

- proactivity/initiative
- time spent on the task / flexible attitude towards (extra) workload

INTERACTION WITH THE SUPERVISOR

- preparations for meetings
- following advice (what has been agreed upon)
- open for discussion (own vs. other opinion)
- ability to discuss

B. SCIENTIFIC WORK

CLEAR DEFINITION OF RESEARCH HYPOTHESES AND GOALS**COHERENCE**

- meaningful and systematic research steps
- methodological appropriateness
- meaningful comparisons wrt. external and internal topics

COMPLETENESS

- fulfillment of goals defined in the proposal
- addressing additional questions that came up during meetings
- related work

CORRECTNESS

- applications / implementation / (experimental|study) design
- evaluation
- proofs

ORIGINALITY

- innovativeness
- creativity
- own valuable ideas

SUSTAINABILITY

- reusability of data, code, tools
- replicability
- availability
- documentation

C. WRITTEN DOCUMENT

MEANINGFUL STRUCTURE

- internal structural coherence / reasonable table of content
- good balance of the different parts/sections

COHERENCE

- common ground (motivation, examples, hypotheses, ...)
- roter Faden / golden thread
- argumentation/discussion/contextualization/interpretation

QUALITY OF WRITING

- grammar
- readability (compact, well-written sentences)
- spelling
- scientific style (appropriate for the research field)
- consistency of terminology (use always same terms, introduce acronyms, ...)

QUALITY OF THE PRESENTATION

- meaningful visualization
- correctness of visualization (axes labels, ...)
- layout of the document/pages (margins, tables, ...)
- quality of figures (resolution, colors, ...)

METALEVEL

- introduction/motivation
- bigger picture
- conclusions
- future work

REFERENCES

- correct and complete citations
- correct and consistent style/format (in text and at the end)